

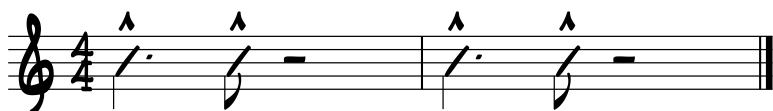
A LESSON W/ JAMES P. JOHNSON

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #126

The Charleston Rhythm is the backbone of jazz, and it's musical DNA is found all over the world, ranging from South America, Central America, North America, the Caribbean, West Africa and much more. Although James P. Johnson, the father of Harlem Stride piano, didn't "invent" the rhythm, he composed the song "The Charleston" in 1922 which helped popularize it.

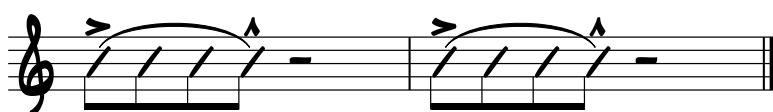
The Charleston Rhythm is the perfect jazz rhythm. It has a grounding downbeat, but also the important syncopation that makes jazz have the feel it does. Pianists and guitarists use this rhythm practically every time they comp in a jazz band, and seasoned soloists use the rhythm, and variations of it, in their melodic solo lines. Spending some time internalizing this sound is one of the most important investments a jazz player can make.

#1 - The Charleston Rhythm



"Beat one," and the "+" of two." The Charleston, most observe, comes from the 3-2 clave rhythm, and West Africa before that.

#2 - Variation



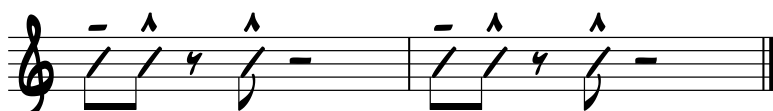
Filling in the 8th notes still gives us the underpinnings of the rhythm. Beat one, and the + of two are still what we hear and feel.

#3 - Variation



Really, any 8th note based rhythm that begins on beat one and ends on the + of two maintains the feel and bounce of the Charleston.

#4 - Variation



Articulation is an important aspect of most rhythms. In these examples, the short + of two is an important aspect that makes the rhythm sound correct.